

Back on the Rack

A Cross-Asset Perspective on Section 301 Tariffs

SPEAKERS

Jenna Giannelli Credit Analyst
Arunima Sinha Global Economist
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Martin Tobias, CFA, CMT US Rates Strategist
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Today's Speakers

Fixed Income, Economics, Public Policy and Equity Research

Jenna Giannelli

Credit Analyst | Retail & Consumer Corporate
Credit

Frames the key takeaways and the credit-specific read-through.

Arunima Sinha

Global Economist

Realized effective tariff rates and the consumer inflation impulse.

Ariana Salvatore

Equity Strategist, US Public Policy

Durability of the 10% to 12.5% baseline and implementation risk.

Martin Tobias, CFA, CMT

US Rates Strategist

IEEPA refund math: \$99bn paid, how much is left to run.

Simeon Gutman, CFA

Equity Analyst | Hardlines, Broadlines & Food
Retail

Sporting goods and furniture as the clearest equity winners.

Alex Straton

Equity Analyst | Softlines Retail & Brands

Embedded 2H tariff assumptions and 2H EPS upside.

Executive Summary: An Underappreciated Relief

Section 301 preserves most of 1H26's tariff relief, limits renewed inflation risk and supports 2H26 to 2027 margin, earnings and cash flow

Our Retail / Consumer basket lands at a 12% all-in effective rate under Section 301, only 1.0ppt above Section 122 and 8ppt below the calendar-weighted IEEPA regime. Not a low-tariff world, but a materially more stable and less inflationary run-rate than we believe many companies and investors assumed.

1 Peak tariff shock is behind the consumer complex

Consumer goods basket at 12% under Section 301 vs. 19% under average IEEPA; softlines at 24% vs. 35%. Realized World rates across nine consumer categories fell from 17% in 4Q25 to 10% in April to May 2026.

2 The 2027 margin story is timing-driven

On an illustrative 90-day inventory-to-COGS lag, costs fade in 2Q26, flip to the strongest YoY tailwind in 3Q26, and stay supportive through 1H27 before comps normalize in 2H27.

3 The biggest winners paid the most, and likely keep the price

Softlines carrying high embedded 2H tariff assumptions, plus furniture and sporting goods with pricing power and direct-importer refund eligibility.

4 The credit benefit is recurring; IEEPA refunds are not

Lower landed costs lift gross margin, EBITDA and FCF. Refunds accelerate 2Q26 / 3Q26 cash flow but should sit outside the run-rate.

5 Policy is durable at the baseline, but not static beneath it

Continuity around 10% to 12.5%. The swing factors are litigation outcomes, affordability into the midterms and the USMCA negotiations.

Source: USTR, USITC, Morgan Stanley Research estimates. See "Back on the Rack: Cross-Asset Perspective on Section 301 Tariffs," August 3, 2026.

Agenda

Prepared comments from the report authors, followed by live Q&A

1	Section 301 by the numbers What the July 24 framework actually costs the consumer complex, and when it hits the P&L	Jenna Giannelli
2	Keeping the lid on tariff inflation Realized effective rates have already stepped down 7ppt; the incremental impulse is small	Arunima Sinha
3	Durable headline, uneven implementation A 10% to 12.5% baseline that holds, with litigation, USMCA and midterms underneath	Ariana Salvatore
4	Sizing the IEEPA refund tailwind \$99bn refunded through July 29; roughly one-quarter to one-third still outstanding	Martin Tobias, CFA, CMT
5	Credit: where the margin benefit lands Retail / Apparel captures the larger tailwind; Consumer Products smaller but still positive	Jenna Giannelli
6	Equity Hardlines: who keeps the price Sporting goods and furniture retail screen best on pricing power and refund eligibility	Simeon Gutman, CFA
7	Equity Softlines: 2H EPS upside Coverage embedded 2H tariff assumptions above the new rates; LULU and VSXY screen best	Alex Straton

Source: Morgan Stanley Research.

SECTION 1

Section 301 by the Numbers

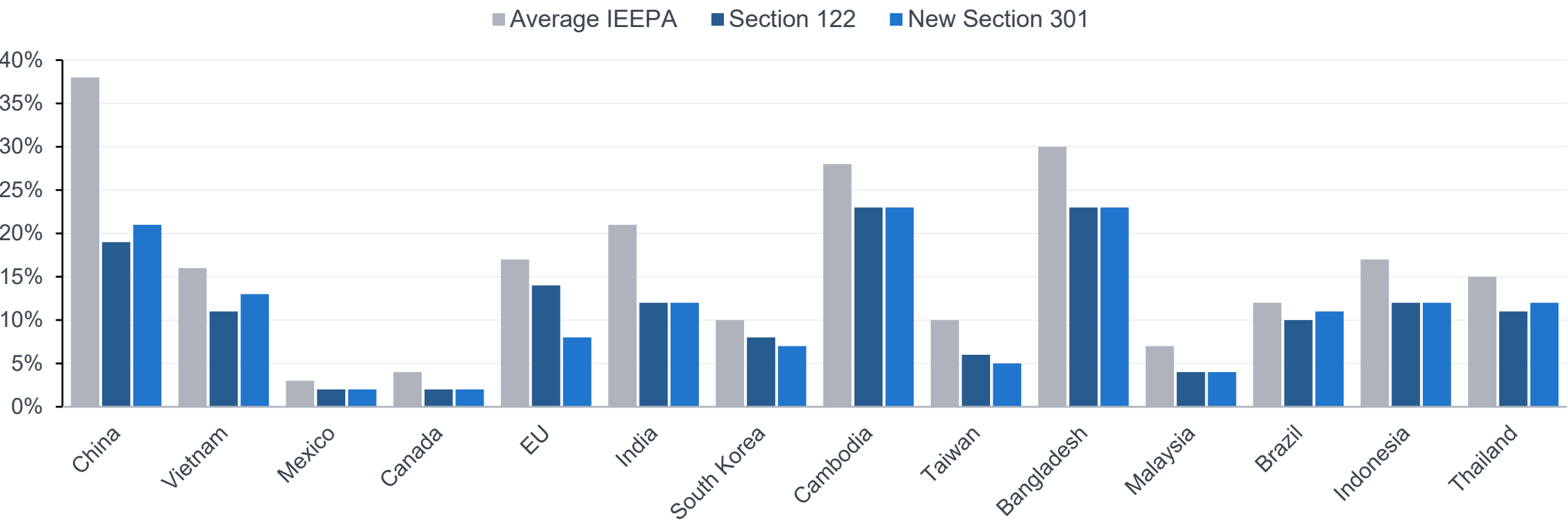
What the July 24 framework actually costs the consumer complex, and when the relief reaches the P&L

Jenna Giannelli, Credit Analyst

Section 301 Cuts Peak IEEPA Rates Across Every Major Sourcing Market

China sees the largest absolute relief (38% → 21%); the EU benefits most versus Section 122 (14% → 8%), while China and Vietnam step modestly higher

All-in effective consumer goods tariff rate by sourcing market and tariff regime (%)



Rates stay above pre-IEEPA levels almost everywhere, so geographic mix remains a key determinant of company-level exposure. Key softlines hubs Cambodia and Bangladesh hold at 23%, Vietnam at 13%.

Source: United States Trade Representative (USTR), Morgan Stanley Research. Note: Fixed 2024 Retail / Consumer import mix across key consumer-goods sourcing markets (~70% of category imports); models statutory tariffs, MFNs, the effective legacy China Section 301 layer and regime-specific exclusions.

Better Than a “Midpoint” Outcome: 12% Blended, 24% Softlines

Investors were largely positioned for a rate near the middle of Section 122 and IEEPA (15%); Section 301 lands close to Section 122 instead

Category average all-in effective rates across tariff regimes

CATEGORY	2024 IMPORT VALUE (\$BN)	PRE-IEEPA	AVERAGE IEEPA	SECTION 122	NEW SECTION 301	NEW VS. AVG IEEPA
Apparel	\$93.0	15%	35%	25%	24%	-11ppt
Footwear	\$40.9	14%	36%	24%	24%	-11ppt
Accessories & travel goods	\$38.1	16%	35%	25%	22%	-13ppt
Home / furniture / housewares	\$118.9	9%	26%	16%	16%	-10ppt
Consumer electronics	\$343.6	2%	11%	5%	6%	-5ppt
Beauty / personal care / household	\$47.0	4%	16%	11%	9%	-7ppt
Toys / sporting / leisure	\$48.8	2%	29%	11%	13%	-16ppt
Food / beverage / consumables	\$114.0	3%	11%	6%	5%	-6ppt
Softlines composite	\$171.9	15%	35%	25%	24%	-11ppt
All consumer categories	\$844.3	6%	19%	11%	12%	-8ppt

Softlines remains the structural pressure point. Apparel, footwear and accessories carry high MFN duties before any Section 301 layer, and China retains the legacy 2018 to 2019 Section 301 tariffs on top.

Source: USTR, Morgan Stanley Research. Note: A simple Section 122 / IEEPA midpoint would imply 15% for all consumer categories and 30% for softlines.

The Call Is About Cadence, Not the July 24 Headline

Tariff costs peaked in the 3Q25 P&L; 3Q26 should show the strongest YoY tailwind, with support persisting through 1H27

When tariff costs reach the P&L: illustrative 90-day inventory-to-COGS lag

Reporting calendar quarter	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	1Q28E
Imported goods quarter	4Q24	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26	4Q26	1Q27	2Q27	3Q27	4Q27
Regime in import quarter	Pre-IEEPA	IEEPA starts	Peak IEEPA	IEEPA normal	Late IEEPA	IEEPA / 122	Section 122	122 / 301	Section 301	Section 301	Section 301	Section 301	Section 301
Margin read-through	Flat	Modest HW	Peak HW	Elevated HW	Elevated HW	Modest HW	Peak TW	Strong TW	Strong TW	Tailwind	Slight HW	Flat	Flat

2Q26

Residual IEEPA pressure still washing through (a fading headwind, not yet a benefit).

3Q26E

The strongest YoY tariff-cost tailwind as Section 122 inventory replaces peak IEEPA goods.

4Q26E to 1H27E

Support persists; equity upside where embedded assumptions were higher and pricing sticks.

2H27E

Closer to flat as the comparison fully annualizes the new Section 301 run-rate.

Company-specific inventory turns can shift this cadence by a quarter in either direction; we view 60 to 120 days as a reasonable sensitivity range.

Source: Morgan Stanley Research estimates. HW = headwind, TW = tailwind. Schedule is purely illustrative. Faster-turn businesses may recognize the benefit earlier, while seasonal or slower-turn models may lag.

Softlines Is Still the Structural Pressure Point

High MFN duties plus China's legacy 2018 to 2019 Section 301 layer keep apparel, footwear and accessories elevated; electronics and food are the relative winners

New Section 301: all-in effective rate by select sourcing market and category (%)

CATEGORY	CHINA	VIETNAM	INDONESIA	BANGLADESH	INDIA	TAIWAN	EU	MEXICO
Apparel	34.9%	27.9%	28.0%	25.0%	24.0%	13.0%	10.5%	4.0%
Footwear	32.8%	26.4%	21.3%	15.8%	20.0%	14.0%	10.0%	2.5%
Accessories & travel goods	48.9%	21.4%	21.8%	19.6%	18.0%	9.9%	9.9%	4.0%
Home / furniture / housewares	38.5%	13.1%	9.0%	11.0%	12.0%	7.9%	9.4%	2.5%
Beauty / personal care	28.3%	15.8%	11.7%	13.5%	12.5%	8.5%	9.1%	1.5%
Toys / sporting / leisure	15.0%	13.0%	10.7%	11.0%	11.0%	9.6%	9.6%	2.0%
Food / beverage / consumables	15.0%	9.0%	8.0%	9.5%	7.5%	5.5%	6.1%	1.5%
Consumer electronics	10.5%	6.1%	5.2%	6.0%	4.3%	3.6%	3.7%	1.2%

Goods from China face the highest tariff rates, with accessories / travel goods at 48.9% and home / housewares at 38.5%. Consumer electronics averages ~6% and food ~5%, which is why broad market averages overstate pressure on electronics-heavy importers and understate it for softlines.

Source: USTR, USITC, Morgan Stanley Research estimates. Note: Includes country MFN + effective legacy China Section 301 + regime-specific exemptions. Cambodia, Thailand, Canada and Malaysia shown in the full report exhibit.

SECTIONS 2 TO 4

Macro, Policy and the Refund Tailwind

Why the incremental inflation impulse is small, what could still move underneath a durable headline, and how much refund cash is left to come

Arunima Sinha, Global Economist · **Ariana Salvatore, Equity Strategist** · **Martin Tobias, CFA, CMT, US Rates Strategist**

Keeping the Lid On: Section 301 Limits a Renewed Inflation Impulse

Realized effective rates have already stepped down 7ppt since 4Q25; the change from here (the margin that matters for pricing decisions) is small

17% → 10%

World effective rate across nine consumer categories, 4Q25 to April to May 2026

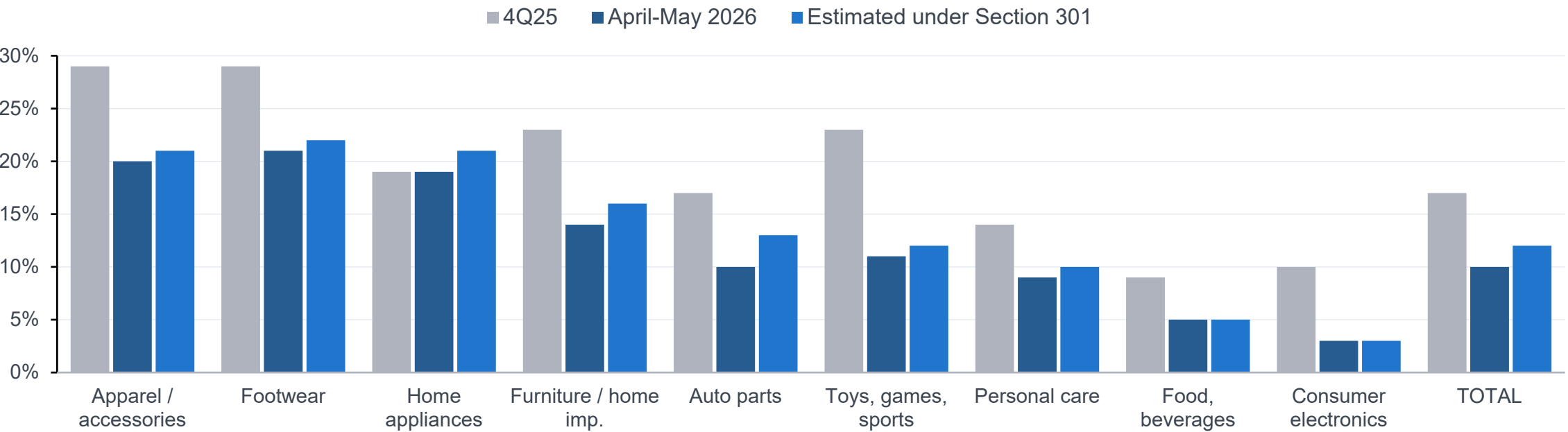
+1ppt

Median category increase under Section 301 vs. April to May realized rates

4 to 11ppt

Lower than 4Q25 in eight of the nine consumer categories

Effective tariff rates by consumer goods category, World basis (%)



Source: United States International Trade Commission (USITC), Morgan Stanley Research. Note: Historical rates are customs-value weighted, so changes reflect product and sourcing mix as well as tariff policy. Section 301 estimates use January to April 2026 trade volumes. Not directly comparable to the modelled import-mix rates on earlier slides.

Section 301 Leaves Our Inflation Outlook Unchanged

The new duties took effect as Section 122 expired (a handoff, not a tariff cliff), and the resulting ~2pp step-up in the effective rate is already inside our forecast

~70bp

cumulative addition to PCE inflation from tariffs, our unchanged forecast

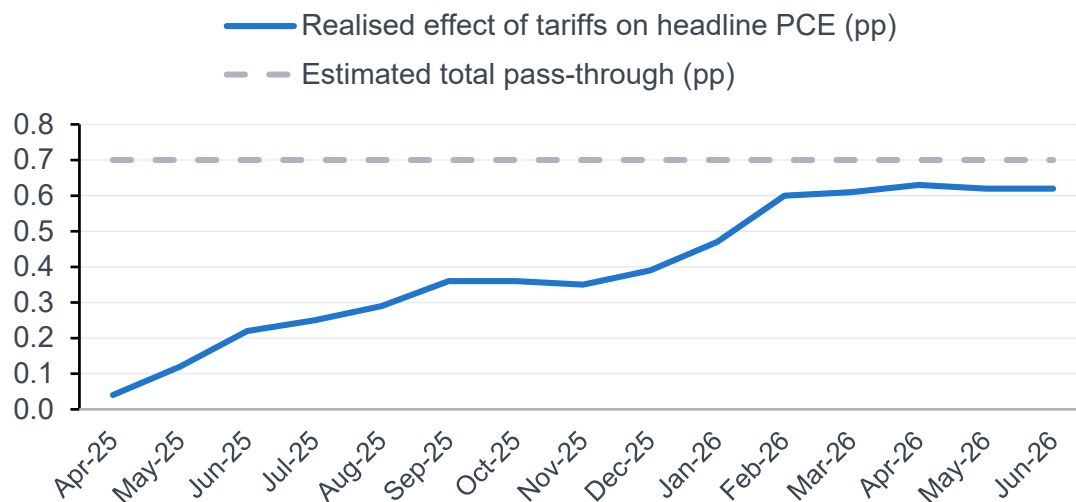
~62bp

already realised, per our tariff pass-through tracker

Since Feb

realised pass-through has been broadly stable

Cumulative tariff pass-through to PCE inflation (pp)



What this does, and does not, change

- **No change to the inflation call.**
Consistent with both our expectations and our current forecast.
- **The impulse had already peaked.**
Broadly stable since February. The impulse from tariffs already in place had nearly peaked.
- **Section 301 is the final push, not a new shock.**
The more stable duties should close the remaining gap to 70bp rather than add upside risk.
- **Statutory rate still converges to ~10%.**
Section 232 remains the targeted sectoral overlay for strategic and capital-intensive goods.

Remaining uncertainty is about implementation (pending Section 232 actions and country-specific escalation), not the persistence of the broad tariff floor.

Source: BEA, Morgan Stanley Research. See “U.S. Data Pulse: Tariffs and inflation: Section 301 forced-labor tariffs leave our inflation outlook unchanged,” July 24, 2026. Note: Realised rates can differ from statutory estimates because of product exclusions, MFN caps, bilateral arrangements, refunds and changes in import composition.

A Durable Headline, With Uneven Implementation Underneath

The administration prioritised continuity in replacing Section 122; we expect the 10% to 12.5% baseline to hold

Base case: continuation of current policy, even if the tariffs are litigated through several courts, consistent with the precedent set by the IEEPA challenges.

WHAT HOLDS THE HEADLINE UP

- Baseline of 10% to 12.5% is largely consistent with prior levels, and we expect it to stay around that level.
- Section 301 rests on much firmer legal footing than IEEPA, with clear precedent, China being the obvious example.
- Limited near-term catalysts to change the aggregate level.

WHAT COULD CREATE AN 'AIR POCKET'

- Litigation risk remains: some importers have already challenged the new regime at the Court of International Trade.
- Affordability into the midterms has driven recent exceptions, carve-outs and delays. We expect more of the same.
- Limited legal authority to hold tariffs on goods that are neither national-security relevant nor tied to a live Section 301 investigation.

Swing factors we are watching

Litigation

CIT challenges to the forced-labor framework

USMCA

Negotiations set effective rates for our largest partners

Midterms

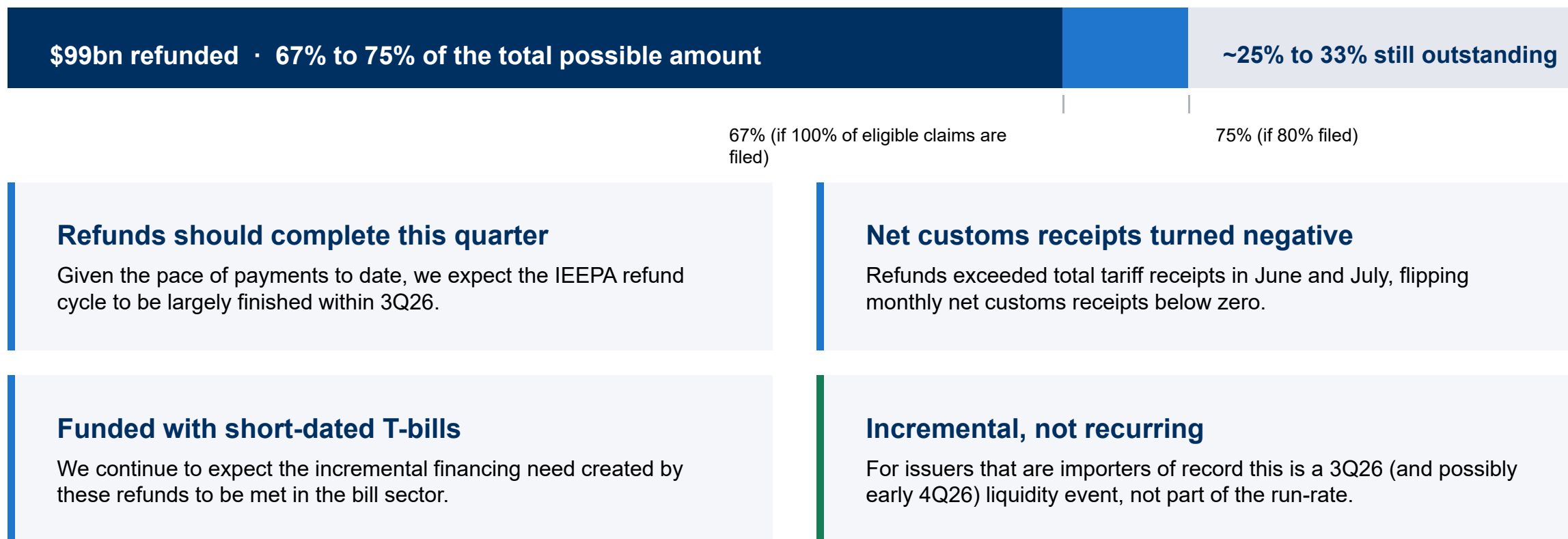
Affordability pressure into November

Source: Morgan Stanley Research.

\$99bn Refunded: Most of the IEEPA Cash Is Already Back

We estimate roughly one-quarter to one-third of eligible refunds is still outstanding, providing an incremental 3Q26 cash flow tailwind

Progress on IEEPA duty refunds, as of July 29, 2026



Source: Morgan Stanley Research, US Treasury, Bloomberg. Note: Estimates are based on cumulative additional withdrawals from US Customs and Border Protection in 2026 vs. 2025, from May 12 of each year. The 67% to 75% range depends on whether 80% or 100% of eligible refund claims are submitted by importers.

SECTIONS 5 TO 7

Sector Implications: Who Paid, Who Keeps It

Where the margin benefit lands in credit, and which equities screen best on exposure, pricing power and refund eligibility

Jenna Giannelli, Credit Analyst · **Simeon Gutman, CFA, Equity Analyst** · **Alex Straton, Equity Analyst**

Credit: Retail / Apparel Captures the Larger Tailwind

~65% of Retail / Apparel COGS is sourced from Asia, including ~22% from China. The sector absorbed an outsized cost burden and should now see the largest reversal

~65%

of Retail / Apparel COGS sourced from Asia

~22%

of COGS sourced from China

2H26 to 1H27

when the margin and EBITDA benefit is most visible

Relative exposure rankings across our Retail / Apparel coverage (most exposed at top)

CHINA SOURCING

ASO · MIK · QVCN · W · DDS · KSS · M · AS · RH · HD · LOW · WOOF · CROX · WWW · TPR · BBWI · GAP · SBH · CRI · VFC · VSXY · UA · LEVI

TOTAL ASIA SOURCING

CROX · TPR · ASO · CRI · VSXY · W · KSS · WWW · AS · UA · GAP · DDS · VFC · RH · LEVI · M · MIK · QVCN · HD · LOW · WOOF · SBH · BBWI

GROSS TARIFF HEADWIND (% OF SALES)

MIK · GAP · UA · RH · VSXY · KSS · CRI · ASO · QVCN · M · WWW · DDS · CROX · AS · VFC · HD · LOW · LEVI · SBH · TPR · WOOF · BBWI · W

Geography matters, but it is not the only driver

Tariff sensitivity also depends on position in the supply chain (direct importer vs. retailer of third-party brands), domestic vs. global sales mix, and gross-margin profile. The most sensitive issuers combine elevated direct sourcing with margin structures that amplify changes in landed cost: MIK, GAP, VSXY, KSS, RH, UA and CRI. Higher-margin, more internationally diversified or more domestically sourced names (BBWI, WOOF, W, SPLS, SBH, LEVI) face lower headwinds, though still more than most non-retail consumer sectors.

Pricing across discretionary categories has held up better than we and many investors expected. As higher-cost inventory rolls through, issuers that retain that pricing should realise a favourable price-cost spread, first in gross margin and EBITDA, then in FCF and deleveraging capacity.

Source: Company filings, Morgan Stanley Research estimates. Rankings shown in descending order of estimated exposure.

Credit: Consumer Products, Smaller Upside but Still Positive

A “no worse” outcome versus Section 122, with NWL, COTY, ENR and EPC the more meaningful beneficiaries across our coverage

~7%

of COGS sourced from China

~13.5%

of COGS sourced from Asia

~2.25%

average gross tariff headwind as a share of sales

Relative exposure rankings across our Consumer Products coverage (most exposed at left)

CHINA SOURCING

EPC · SPB · SGI · COTY · NWL · SMG · ENR · PBH · WHR · CENT

TOTAL ASIA SOURCING

NWL · SPB · EPC · WHR · SGI · COTY · CENT · SMG · ENR · PBH

GROSS TARIFF HEADWIND (% OF SALES)

ENR · EPC · WHR · NWL · SMG · SGI · SPB · COTY · PBH · CENT

WHY THE UPSIDE IS SMALLER

Materially lower China and Asia sourcing exposure, less pricing power than discretionary categories, and a category mix that receives less tariff relief, capping the absolute dollar benefit.

WHY IT STILL MATTERS

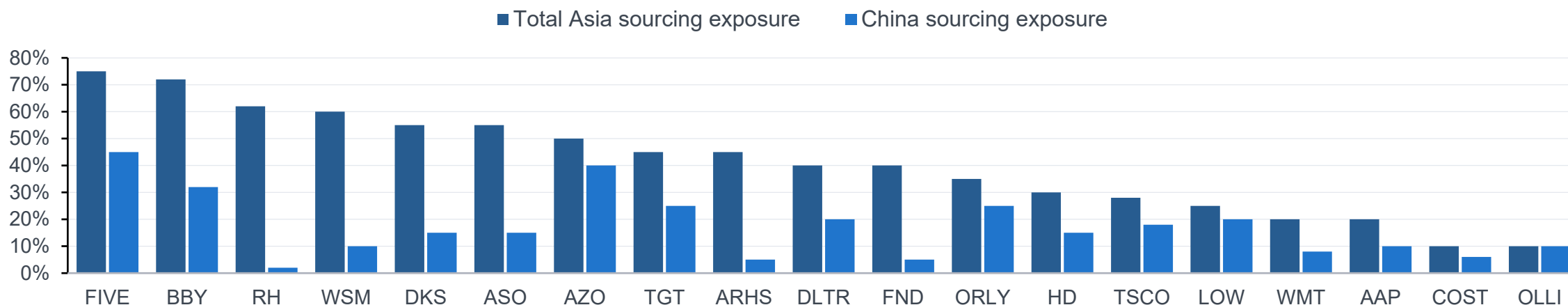
Lower gross margins and rising consumer elasticity have made tariffs harder to offset here, so even modest costs weighed on profitability. A better COGS backdrop and greater cost stability into late 2027 should support EBITDA, FCF and leverage.

Source: Company filings, Morgan Stanley Research estimates. Rankings shown in descending order of estimated exposure; see Exhibits 16 to 18 of the underlying report for magnitudes.

Hardlines: Sporting Goods and Furniture Look Best Situated

FIVE, BBY, RH and WSM lead on Asia sourcing; our coverage averages ~17% estimated exposure to China

Estimated COGS sourcing exposure by retailer (%)



Biggest beneficiaries of the IEEPA to Section 301 transition

Sporting Goods

GOLF, CALY, DKS

Secular growth, innovation and the World Cup; higher-income households enjoying the wealth effect; gross-margin upside as tariff costs subside.

High pricing power

Home Furnishings

RH, WSM, ARHS, BOBS

Affluent household spending remains resilient; substantial tariff impact of ~4% to 6%; relatively limited price sensitivity on higher-ticket purchases.

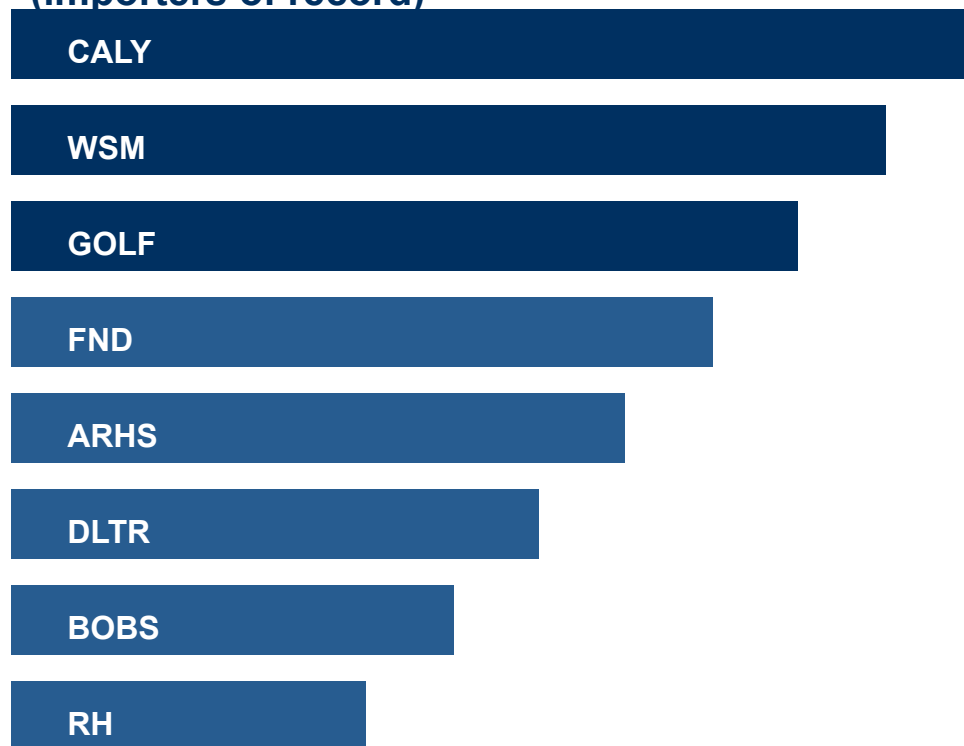
High pricing power

Source: Company data, Morgan Stanley Research estimates. Note: Estimated COGS exposure to Asia and to China across Hardlines / Broadlines / Food Retail coverage.

Refunds: Who Collects, and What They Do With It

A tailwind to 2Q26e and 3Q26e P&Ls, but where it lands in earnings depends entirely on whether the cash is reinvested, offset or retained

Largest expected refunds as a share of US revenue (importers of record)



Ranked highest to lowest; estimated refund as a % of US revenue ranges up to ~4%.

Source: Company data, Morgan Stanley Research estimates. Note: Refund eligibility applies to direct claimants as importers of record; timing and use of proceeds will vary by company. We view refunds as incremental to, rather than part of, the recurring margin benefit from lower go-forward tariff costs.

Expected use of proceeds across the coverage universe

Price reinvestment

Broadlines (WMT, COST, TGT, BJ) should push refunds back into price, particularly in grocery.

Cost offsets

Home Improvement (HD, LOW, FND) will likely deploy some of it against higher freight and transportation costs.

Flow-through to earnings

Sporting Goods, led by golf equipment manufacturers GOLF and CALY, plus DKS, should see the strongest earnings flow-through.

No direct claim

Auto parts (ORLY, AZO, AAP) and category specialists (ULTA, BBY, TSCO, WOOF, SBH) paid tariffs through suppliers but are not importers of record.

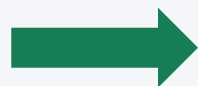
Softlines: 2H EPS Upside, With LULU and VSXY Screening Best

Coverage generally embedded 2H tariff assumptions above the new incremental Section 301 rate for apparel and accessories

The gap that creates the upside

~20%

Incremental tariff rate
embedded by LULU and
VSXY



~10%

New incremental Section
301 rate for apparel and
accessories

Both names embedded roughly double the new incremental rate, making them the clearest potential beneficiaries in our coverage. Across the group, every company with a disclosed 2H tariff assumption (all but BBWI and KSS) now carries potential upside versus current EPS guidance.

Upside, not downside

We see no clear downside EPS risk related to this development for Softlines Retail.

Consensus is beatable

Consistent with our coverage resumption view that '26e consensus estimates are fair-to-beatable.

One of several drivers

Additional tariff mitigation and/or relief is one of several potential upside drivers, not the whole story.

Note: Rates are the difference between post-Section 301 forecast category tariff rates and 2024 actual rates; category forecasts weight country-specific rates by January to April trade volumes. Implied company rates are calculated from company commentary.

Source: Company filings, Morgan Stanley Research. See Exhibit 24 of the underlying [report](#) for company-level embedded assumptions.

Where We Go From Here

The debate shifts from the level of tariffs to the cadence of relief, and to what companies choose to do with it

Section 301 is not a return to a low-tariff world. It is a more stable, materially less inflationary run-rate than many companies and investors had assumed, and it arrives as the hardest YoY comparisons roll off.

What we are watching from here

- **Litigation**
Court of International Trade challenges to the forced-labor framework
- **USMCA**
Negotiations that set effective rates for our largest trading partners
- **Midterm affordability**
Further carve-outs, exceptions and delays into November
- **Section 338s on Canada**
Announced, with implementation date of August 19, 2026

What we will be testing on the print

Does the pricing hold?

The upside depends on retaining tariff-driven price as landed costs fall. Watch gross margin bridges, not just headline beats.

Refunds: kept, reinvested or offset?

Separate the one-time IEEPA cash from the recurring margin benefit. Ask management where the proceeds went.

Whose guidance was too conservative?

Companies with embedded 2H assumptions above the new rates have room; those without disclosure are harder to underwrite.

Source: Morgan Stanley Research. See [“Back on the Rack: Cross-Asset Perspective on Section 301 Tariffs,”](#) August 3, 2026.

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(as of July 31, 2026)

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Disclosure Section (Cont.)

Stock Rating Category	Coverage Universe		Investment Banking Clients (IBC)			Other Material Investment Services Clients (MISC)	
	Count	% of Total	Count	% of Total IBC	% of Rating Category	Count	% of Total Other MISC
Overweight/Buy	1529	42%	442	47%	29%	750	43%
Equal-weight/Hold	1582	43%	396	42%	25%	773	44%
Not-Rated/Hold	3	0%	1	0%	33%	1	0%
Underweight/Sell	560	15%	97	10%	17%	217	12%
Total	3,674		936			1741	

Data include common stock and ADRs currently assigned ratings. Investment Banking Clients are companies from whom Morgan Stanley received investment banking compensation in the last 12 months. Due to rounding off of decimals, the percentages provided in the "% of total" column may not add up to exactly 100 percent.

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